

young age, she feels. The world of school girls, 12 to 18, is fascinating, if not a pretty sight, explains Sen. A few socially-dominant girls set the standards for many others, exercise control with some of the meanest tactics, using exclusion and abuse. And much of this is played out on physical appearance, because of their preoccupation with the body. "They do all this for power and perhaps to control access to the most attractive boys." The Internet seems to have become yet another tool for such girl-games.

For Rinku Kanjilal, it was a knockout punch when one morning she logged on and her Facebook live feed (the ticker that loads up all the updates from your friends in real-time) showed up two of her 'friends' discussing her:

BITCHING ABOUT: The freedom to abuse



BANDEEP SINGH

GIRLS PUT IN PICTURES OF THEIR FACE TAKEN FROM ALL ANGLES TO ESCAPE THE DREADED 'HAHAHA' TAG.

"Kiran Seth wrote on Neetu Misra's wall: he needs to get his eyes checked coz Rinku's got the most dirtiest TEETH line ever!!", went the first line. The second line read, "Neetu Misra wrote on Kiran Seth's wall: yep." The third line said, "Kiran Seth wrote on Neetu Misra's wall: n more-over ... she's DUMB." "Being bodysnarked by a stranger is bad enough, but by people you know can be devastating," says Kanjilal. "What upset me more was that before I could catch on, their hostility was all uploaded on the Net for the world to see and smirk at."

Women acting as judge and jury on other women's appearance is not necessarily new, feels Samita Sen, who heads the School of Women's Studies at Jadavpur University, Kolkata. "It's an old phenomenon, linked to the way society looks at women," she says. "Men don't need to compete with each other on the ba-

sis of looks, women do. Because, women are in the market on the basis of how they look." As technology allows more private photos into the Net space, the room for corrosive comments has escalated to online trash talk. "What was once a problem of women competing with each other in their everyday lives, has now found a new medium," she adds. "After all, you can't be held accountable on the Net. You don't have eye contact. And you can be as nasty as you please."

Is it just female bitchiness and oneupmanship? Not quite. "The Web is a tool for bringing together millions of people and making them matter," says marketing communication professional Rajesh Lalwani, the CEO of Blog Works. "Thanks to social networking hubs, photo-sharing services and blogs, everybody is now a 'celebrity'." But as millions of minds get backhauled into digital democracy, the stupidity of crowds as well as the wisdom gets harnessed. "Some of the comments on Web can send shivers down your spine just for the obscenity and the naked hatred," he says. As technology provides a chance for people to look at a computer screen and take a peek at other lives, there's curiosity and a lot of disgust, as mundane little lives get raised to high cyber snoot.

Much-read blogger Suchismita's posting, "Bitchy on a Wednesday Afternoon", on wordpress.com is a musing on this. "I am on Orkut all day," she writes, "snooping around. Old friends, school pricks, college bitches, old flames, I go to each one's profile, and more importantly, to each one's album... I find ample entertainment in seeing the erstwhile geek put up photos of her new married life... It is as much my fault for viewing these as it is her for putting them up. More mine, because I can never tell her how weird it is to post pictures of a half-eaten middle class dinner, only because I do not want a caustic defence sent to me on a public forum. And when I am up to my eyeballs with disgust with the pictures, I go over to her blog. I...have reservations against women who are so besotted with their new wife status... My apologies for sounding downright bitchy but honestly, I could do without the details."

Meanwhile in the digital world, it's survival of the snarkiest. If some are proclaiming (say, the members of the bombaybitch.com) bitchiness as a uniquely female virtue that makes women fearless mistresses of their own destinies, advice portals are giving "top tips" on "how to stop being a bitch". Bloggers are locking horns: is bodysnarking new or just getting a wider audience now? Feminists are questioning why a bitch-fest starts whenever women come together. With it all, let's hope, the only people who can do anything about this—namely, the bitchy women—will finally put on their thinking caps.